



THE FANS OF GOD

KOLKATA HAS seen frenzied crowds but seldom like those that welcomed Diego Maradona to the City of Joy. Despite the midnight hour, thousands received him at the airport and the police struggled to hold back fans at his many public appearances, including a mammoth public reception at Salt Lake stadium.

CHANDIGARH | No Silver Lining

Chief Minister Parkash Singh Badal is opposing the creation of a federal anti-terror agency, demanding economic federalism and resurrecting the party's long-dormant demand for the merger of Chandigarh into Punjab. Badal's anti-UPA tirade has grown shriller as SAD and its alliance partner, the BJP, have switched to poll mode, announcing candidates for seven of the state's 13 Parliamentary constituencies. Badal's line is clearly a different one from the BJP's, which is amenable to such an agency. Badal is also pitching for the states to get at least 50 per cent of gross Central receipts from taxes, a demand necessitated by Punjab's deepening resource crunch. With SAD losing all four seats it contested in the Delhi Assembly polls and the BJP's below par performance, Badal has all the more reasons to harp on his anti-Centre rhetoric. *by Ramesh Vinayak*

**BADAL'S
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HEMANT CHAWLA